

Q HOW DOES STRESS FIT INTO TRADITIONAL YOGIC PHILOSOPHY?

A 2018 article in *Frontiers in Human Neuroscience* aligns the ancient wisdom of yoga, particularly the gunas, with the role of the vagus nerve in our physiological response to stress and relaxation.

The vagus nerve is the only cranial nerve that leaves the head and neck area. It is mainly responsible for your relaxation response: telling your heart to slow down, improving your digestion, and encouraging social connection. Rather than an “on/off” switch, the stress and relaxation responses work more like a dial or dimmer knob. This allows adjustment to the perfect blend of electrical activity

from each branch of your autonomic nervous system (ANS) for the situation (see below).

According to the Polyvagal Theory proposed by American neuroscientist Stephen Porges, PhD, the vagus nerve is split functionally in a way that helps us adjust effectively. Researchers have explained this neural adaptability in terms of the gunas. Gunas means “thread” or quality. The three gunas—sattvic, rajasic, and tamasic—are the three essential aspects of nature that weave together to create what we observe as the reality of the material world (also known as prakriti) with its ever-changing conditions. Each of the gunas is associated with a state of mind and certain characteristics that map against the different functions of the vagus nerve (see below).

